PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #6 · CONFIDENCE WITH PEOPLE · SAFER TO STAY AWAY

“Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Do you steer clear of social situations, new jobs, or new activities because you fear embarrassment or criticism? Do you feel safer staying on the sidelines? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward trying again, and to find the courage that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Repeated criticism, teasing, shaming, or being left out can teach a person that other people are a source of pain. A child who was often corrected harshly, compared with others, or humiliated may learn that staying quiet and out of view is the best way to stay safe. Over time, avoiding feels like wisdom rather than fear.

How the belief can keep itself going

Avoiding gives quick relief, and relief makes avoiding feel like the right choice. But the person never learns that most situations are survivable or that people are often kinder than expected. Skills stay unpracticed, opportunities pass, and loneliness grows, which can seem to confirm the original fear. Small steps, taken gradually, let us gather new evidence.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest about fear and does not shame us for it. The Lord says over and over, “Do not fear,” and ties that command to His presence and help. The fear of other people can become a snare, but trusting the Lord sets us securely. These passages do not call us to be reckless. They remind us that we do not take each step alone.

> *“The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” (Proverbs 29:25)*

Also see

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness.” (Isaiah 41:10)

> “For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control.” (2 Timothy 1:7)

> “When I am afraid, I put my trust in You.” (Psalm 56:3)

> “Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.” (Joshua 1:9)

Common self-statements

- It is safer to stay home than to risk looking foolish.
- I will pass on that job or event; I would only embarrass myself.
- If I never try, I can never fail in front of anyone.
- I will wait until I feel confident before I join in.
- I would rather be alone than be judged.

- Why take the chance when I already know how it will go?

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will embarrass myself before I have tried.
- Catastrophizing: Treating a possible awkward moment as a disaster I could not survive.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of dread as proof that the situation is dangerous.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that if I cannot do it perfectly, I should not do it at all.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring times when I took a risk and it turned out fine.
- Overestimating the cost: Believing others will notice and remember my mistakes far more than they do.

Challenging questions

- What exactly am I afraid will happen, and how likely is it?
- If it did happen, how bad would it really be, and could I cope with it?
- What is the cost of staying away, in friendships, work, and joy?
- Has avoiding ever made the fear smaller in the long run, or larger?
- Can I recall a time I took a small risk and it went better than I expected?
- What is one very small step I could take this week, with God's help?
- If a friend described this fear, what would I encourage them to do?

Truth summary

Feeling afraid is not the same as being in danger. Avoiding gives short-term relief but keeps the fear alive and shrinks my life. I can take small, manageable steps and learn from what actually happens. Embarrassment is uncomfortable, but I can survive it, and God is with me in every step.

A short prayer

Lord, You know how heavy this fear feels. Be my security when I want to hide. Give me courage for one small step today, and remind me that I am never alone. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Trust
- Strength
- Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Anxiety, Worry, Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Trust in God
Elevation Worship feat. Chris Brown

Reflect on trusting God when stepping out feels risky.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Remember God's goodness in each small step you take.

No Longer Slaves
Jonathan David & Melissa Helser

Practice replacing fear with the confidence that you belong to God.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let your identity rest in who God says you are.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call avoidant personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Avoiding feared situations is the most common way anxiety is maintained; gradual exposure is a central treatment for social anxiety and for avoidant patterns, and it can occur with depression, trauma, or other conditions. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Gradual exposure should be paced to the person; anyone with severe anxiety, depression, or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What is one small step I can take today instead of avoiding?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you feel like staying away.

- ☐ What exactly am I afraid will happen, and how likely is it?
- ☐ If it did happen, how bad would it really be, and could I cope with it?
- ☐ What is the cost of staying away, in friendships, work, and joy?
- ☐ Has avoiding ever made the fear smaller in the long run, or larger?
- ☐ Can I recall a time I took a small risk and it went better than I expected?
- ☐ What is one very small step I could take this week, with God's help?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Feeling afraid is not the same as being in danger.
- ☐ I can take small steps and learn from what really happens.
- ☐ Avoiding helps for a moment, but it keeps the fear going.
- ☐ I can survive embarrassment, and I can grow from it.
- ☐ I do not have to feel confident first; I can act while still nervous.
- ☐ God is with me, so I do not face each step alone.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Proverbs 29:25
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ 2 Timothy 1:7
  "For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control."

- [ ] Psalm 56:3
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."
- [ ] Joshua 1:9
  "Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Fear. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Choose one small, low-risk social step this week, such as greeting a neighbor or sending a short message. Predict what will happen, then record what did.
- ☐ Say yes to one small invitation or activity you would normally decline. Stay for a set short time, then notice how it went.
- ☐ Ask a question or share a short opinion in a group, then rate how bad it actually was from 0 to 10.
- ☐ Try one new activity alone in public, such as a class, a library visit, or a walk in a busy place. Note what you feared and what happened.
- ☐ Make a “fear ladder” of five situations from easiest to hardest and do the easiest one. Repeat it until it feels easier.
- ☐ Write an honest prayer about what scares you, then choose one small step to take today.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about courage, trust, and taking small steps with God.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment.~~

NEW TRUTH:
Fear is not danger. I can take small steps, learn from what happens, and trust that God is with me.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Proverbs 29:25

A short prayer

Lord, thank You that You are with me. Give me courage for small steps, patience with myself, and trust that I am safe in Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.